

Palm Treo 650

Business on the Go!

The Palm Treo 650, a worthy successor to the Treo 600, still retains its charm as the best PDA-Phone device. With the Treo 650, Palm hasn't done anything revolutionary but made sure most of the drawbacks of its earlier product were fixed, and has added some new features.

The design still remains the same—that's good because the Treo 600 had the perfect balance of size, weight and pocketability; why mess with perfection? The metallic grey and chrome outfit lends the phone smart look and speaks clearly to its targeted audience.

The Treo 650 is powered by a 312 MHz Intel 'Bulverde' Processor, which has enough juice to put the low-resource Palm OS through its paces. The Treo's 2.5-inch, 65K colour screen is one of the most beautiful displays we have seen on any phone. Its 320 x 320 resolution renders sharp text and icons; images are life-like on it.

The Treo 650 uses non-volatile memory and doesn't require power to retain its data, so in case the battery runs out, the data remains safe and intact. With just 32 MB onboard (23 MB useable) there isn't much you can do; however an included SDIO slot allows the Treo's storage capacity to be upgraded to 2 GB; apart from accepting SDIO capable peripherals such as GPS navigation units or high-resolution cameras.

The inbuilt VGA camera can't match what is available on most phones, however it clicks good photos and is a definite improvement over the Treo 600's camera. It also allows video recording and subsequent playback. Integration of Bluetooth is an added bonus for the occasional file sharing; it also allows browsing the internet via a Bluetooth dongle. With the Treo 650, Palm has introduced user-replaceable batteries—a big boon especially for people on the move. Its big, chunky battery holds enough juice to power the Treo 650 for four days or more, on moderate usage.

The Treo bundles RealPlayer and can play MP3 in stereo, but stereo headphones need an optional stereo adapter. The inbuilt speaker volume is high and the ringtones are melodious. A small switch on the top of the phone can mute all sounds, and put the phone in vibrate mode.

As for its PDA capabilities, the Treo 650 has all the common apps provided with standard Palm OS PDAs. Contacts, Calendar, Memo, Web browser, Versa mail, etc., all make for a very strong application bundle and should take care of most needs. The Documents to go application bundle makes allows one to both view and edit MS Office files on the fly, permitting data synchronisation over the PC—just transfer them on to the Palm Treo 650 and you are ready to go. The Blazer Web browser is quite fast and it successfully rendered most of the sites we visited. It also supports cookies and offers cache management. Messaging is brilliant and SMS messages are shown in a conversational format, collating communication with a contact as a unit—better than having multiple entries. Bluetooth support however can improve; if you interrupt a Bluetooth transfer the device at times hangs and requires resetting.

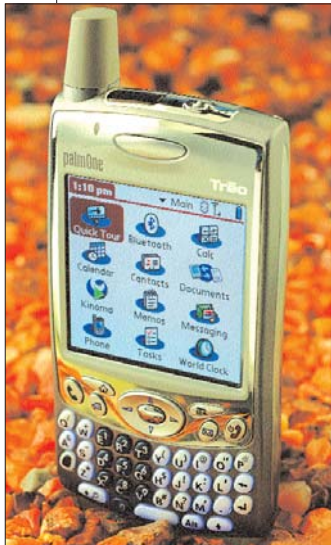
Usability is Treo 650's trump card; nothing comes close to the one-handed operation offered by the Treo 650. Though a stylus is provided, you hardly need it. Most operations can be done using the multitude of buttons. Its QWERTY keyboard is comfortable, once you get used to it. The keyboard is backlit by a bright light and is clearly visible in low-light conditions.

The small stub antenna on the Treo 650 might give the phone an odd look but it makes sure that signal reception is good. During our test the Treo presented no problems as far as reception and sound quality were concerned.

Priced at Rs 29,999, the Treo 650 is one of the best PDA-phone devices we have reviewed so far. Though it lacks features such as Wi-Fi and a good camera, and comes with low inbuilt memory, it makes up for it by offering the best display screen and a purposeful application bundle.

- + Seamless one handed operation
- No Wi-Fi, less onboard memory

Rating: 4.5/5



Palm Treo 650 - The best one handed operation ever



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